STATE SCAN

UTTAR PRADESH: CASTE VS HINDUTVA *PG 14*

J&K: HULLABALOO AT HAZRATBAL *PG 16*



NOT QUITE A LOVE PENTANGLE Nitish; and clockwise, Chirag, Samrat, Kushwaha and Manjhi

Photographs ANI

BIHAR

BIG BATTLE FOR SEAT SHARING IN THE NDA

Even a lesser Nitish is more equal than others. BJP has its own ambitions. So does Chirag. The NDA frets at the math

By **Amitabh Srivastava**

AT 74, NITISH KUMAR SHOWS NO SIGN OF HIS zest for office waning. It's as if time's not passed on: his welfare bonanzas cue that the CM sees the coming assembly poll only as a way station on an endless road. But his kingly caravan is as if on the top tier of Patna's new double decker flyover—there's a surge beneath him, and new cracks on the macadam ahead. Smooth passage will need a math problem to be solved. It's a beguiling one: how to carve up Bihar's 243 seats among the NDA friends.

In 2020, Nitish's JD(U) had kept its usual lion's share of 115 seats. The BJP fought 110, and 18 were parcelled out to smaller allies—Mukesh Sahni's VIP, Jitan Ram Manjhi's HAM et al. Sahni has since joined the INDIA bloc, but the residual challenge is more acute, not less. The NDA must now fit in Chirag Paswan's LJP(RV), which had fought 135 seats solo in 2020. It lost its deposit in 110, while infamously bush-whacking the JD(U). But a restless Chirag, riding on a 5/5 Lok Sabha tally, looks unwilling to settle for cramped quarters.

This is proving to be a big variable. Chirag has set his ante at an unrealistic high of 40, and is threatening to go solo again if pegged down too much. Even if that's halved, it would upset equations, since Manjhi and Upendra Kushwaha's latest